great films. All Indian films that won acclaim at Cannes this year are foreign co-productions. But India will celebrate the wins. Payal is still fighting the case the Film and Television Institute of India filed against her and other students for protesting Gajendra Chauhan's appointment as chairman. It's a 200-page chargesheet that still hasn't been withdrawn. An unsupportive government is now co-opting her win."

Kashyap goes on to explain how the Mumbai film industry, for political reasons as well as unsustainable financial gambles, has become resistant to backing any film slightly off the beaten track. Kashyap's dream project *Maximum City*, based on the Suketu Mehta book, has been in the making for 15 years. Is he still hopeful?

"If we have been trying to make *Maximum City* for 15 years, why will I stop now?" says Kashyap. "Big-tech streamers are not in India to make great art but to try and convert as much of our 1.4 billion population into subscribers. For that, every greenlighting decision is based on algorithms, not passion for cinema. This is a new world, and we must find our way to make our films. Or we start playing the game. It's up to us." ■

–Devarsi Ghosh

CINEMA

Shunning Stereotypes

Writer-producer Kanika Dhillon returns with *Phir Aayi Hasseen Dillruba*, whose divisive lead character Rani makes unapologetic choices and is anything but docile

In 2021, *Haseen Dillruba* grabbed headlines as it became one of the most-watched Netflix original films. It also provoked much discussion of its lead character, Rani (played by Taapsee Pannu). A steamy romantic thriller, it saw Rani cheat on her husband and then tolerate his emotional and physical abuse in the second half. That it was written by a woman–Kanika Dhillon–particularly irked detractors. With the sequel–*Phir Aayi Hasseen Dillruba*–releasing on August 9, Dhillon wouldn't mind more fireworks on social media. "Am I a deliberately provocative writer? Not necessarily," she says. "It's just that my heroines make unapologetic choices, which are read as provocative."

Dhillon has made a career out of busting the myth of the *sati-savitri nari*, instead shining a light on the messy and complex women she has known in real life. Her credits include *Manmarziyaan*, *Judgementall Hai Kya* and *Guilty*, films where one sees varied shades of women, not all of which are appealing. Dhillon feels her next, *Do Patti*, starring Kajol and Kriti Sanon–which she has co-produced–is going to set even more tongues wagging. "Why are my women not allowed to make mistakes? I want to show women who have agency, are sexual beings...I don't want any inhibitions. I want to liberate [myself] from this definition of a good or bad woman," says Dhillon while seated at her toddler's playschool.

Being a mother is not the only new hat she has worn. Dhillon started a production house, Kathha Pictures, to have more ownership of her stories. It currently employs 25 people, a few of whom she said were waiting outside the playschool so that they could immediately meet to work. "I like to see the commerce of writing and also enjoy the solitude and purity of it. It's a nice dichotomy. It keeps me hungry," she says. It means that Dhillon is as invested in her narrative as she is in the budget needed to get the film rolling. A member of the "kill your darlings" club, she can let go of a script that has been a year in the making at the nth hour. The final draft, she says, has to be one that an "actor or producer should be compelled to think about twice before refusing".

Going by her strike rate–she has had a release every year since 2018–the noes are few and far between. In addition to writing, the 39-year-old is forging bonds with actresses who are taken by the compelling sheroes she conjures up. "I believe in the writer-actor combo, and try and write to the strengths of the actor," she adds. For now, Dhillon is ready with her "noise-cancellation airpods" as the divisive Rani takes centre stage to shock as much as to entertain. ■

-Suhani Singh

